

Visual Identity Checklist

The full checklist for building a visual identity system that holds up across every touchpoint, not just the logo.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Designers building a visual identity for a client — from first concept through to final delivery — who want to make sure nothing gets missed between the mood board and the handoff.

HOW TO USE IT

Work through this in project order: Discovery, then Design, then Systemize, then Deliver. Each section is a gate — don't move into the next until the current one is checked.

1. DISCOVERY

- ☐ Client's positioning and target audience are documented, not assumed.
- ☐ Competitor identities have been reviewed, so the new mark doesn't accidentally echo one.
- ☐ References and inspiration are gathered and discussed with the client before concepting starts.
- ☐ Mandatory elements and hard constraints are confirmed in writing.

2. DESIGN

- ☐ Multiple genuinely distinct directions were explored before picking one to refine — not three versions of the same idea.
- ☐ The chosen mark works at business-card size and at billboard size without redesign.
- ☐ The mark works in a single color, and in reverse (white on dark), without losing legibility.
- ☐ Typography pairing has been tested with real client copy, not just placeholder text.
- ☐ Color palette has been checked for accessible contrast, not just aesthetic appeal.

3. SYSTEMIZE

- ☐ Logo variations (primary, icon-only, one-color, reversed) are finalized as vector files.
- ☐ Clear space and minimum size rules are defined and documented.
- ☐ A short list of "never do this" misuse examples is included in the guideline.
- ☐ A supporting graphic device — pattern, texture, or motif — exists beyond the logo itself.
- ☐ Photography, iconography, or illustration style is defined, if relevant to this brand.

4. DELIVER

[] All files are organized and named clearly, not "Final_v3_ACTUALFINAL."

Client should be able to find what they need without asking you.

[] A brand guideline document exists that someone outside the project could follow correctly.

[] The identity has been shown applied to at least one real, finished piece — not only on a mockup.

[] Client has formally signed off before final files are delivered.

STUDIO HABIT

Keep a copy of this checklist, filled out, in every project folder. When a client returns eight months later asking for a variant you never delivered, it's the fastest way to know whether that's new scope or something you missed.

NEXT STEPS

A visual identity isn't finished when the logo is approved — it's finished when someone who has never met you could apply it correctly without guessing. That's the bar this checklist is built to hold you to.